

THE WITCH AND THE CHAMELEON

1974–76 · Amanda Bankier, Hamilton, Ontario. The first explicitly feminist SF fanzine https://fanlore.org/wiki/The_Witch_and_the_Chameleon

WEEK 2 · THE PRACTICE · PERMACOMPUTING

READ & ENCOUNTER ARTWORKS

Work through every item listed below. In all cases, except when indicated, you do not need to READ the entire item. Familiarize yourself with the ideas enough to be able to answer the questions.

CONNECTIONS

FIND	something you did not know before
SPARK	what inspired you, specifically
FRICTION	what upset you, and why
LIVED	your own life, and what it shows beyond you
CHARGE	where you stand, said with conviction
SPECULATE	a work that does not exist yet

Due two hours before class.

YOUR NAME

SECTION

DATE

YOUR SUBMISSION NUMBER ARTIST_

Skim through these links.

01

READINGS · 6 QUESTIONS

Permacomputing

- **Permacomputing** <https://permacomputing.net/permacomputing/>
- **Principles** <https://permacomputing.net/principles/>
- **Original Text** <https://viznut.fi/files/texts-en/permacomputing.html>
- **Issues** <https://permacomputing.net/issues/>
- **Library** <https://permacomputing.net/library/>

FIND

Something you learned that you did not know before. A fact, a quote, a concept, a claim. What is it? Why is it interesting?

Write your answer here. This box keeps growing as you type.

SPARK

What inspired you? Describe the thing — a sentence, an idea, a quote, a concept, a described object— and why it is inspiring to you.

Write your answer here. This box keeps growing as you type.

FRICTION

What upset you. Disagreement, irritation, discomfort, or something you think is simply wrong. Describe it and why you responded this way.

Write your answer here. This box keeps growing as you type.

LIVED

Something in your own life this connects to, and how it connects to the larger world. Two parts: why it relates to your lived experience, then what that experience reveals about other people and the world beyond you.

Write your answer here. This box keeps growing as you type.

CHARGE

What you feel strongly about in the reading OR something that is connected to the reading that you feel strongly about. Take a position and say it with conviction.

Write your answer here. This box keeps growing as you type.

SPECULATE

Propose a speculative artwork.

For this question, think of a speculative artwork as something that does not exist yet, described as though it already does. It can be an object, an image, a film, a publication, a performance, a tool, a garment, a machine, a place, an installation, a software or hardware. What makes it speculative is that you haven't made it yet. Describe it as a real thing in the world, as if it existed.

Describe yours in two or three sentences. Describe its parts, aesthetics, concepts, location, interactive elements, technologies, sounds, movement, etc. It does not have to be buildable or possible.

Write your answer here. This box keeps growing as you type.

Permacomputing Aesthetics

The following two links are to the same paper. Pick one that is easier for you to read. Skim through the text and get a general sense of the ideas.

→ [LIMITS paper](https://limits.pubpub.org/pub/6loh1eqi) (download as PDF) <https://limits.pubpub.org/pub/6loh1eqi>

→ [Readable wiki version](https://monoskop.org/Permacomputing_Aesthetics) https://monoskop.org/Permacomputing_Aesthetics

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A Feminist Server Manifesto

Skim through the text and get a general sense of the ideas.

→ **Open the item** https://areyoubeingserved.constantvzw.org/Summit_afterlife.xhtml

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DEGROWTH

Pick one of the items below to peruse and get a sense of the ideas.

Degrowth: the ideas

→ **Kallis, Degrowth (2018) ch. 1** https://csu-sjsu.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01CALS_SJO/14jett4/alma991078783272602901https://www.cambridge.org/core/books/abs/degrowth/what-is-degrowth/FBC40479FC00A7FFB8DDCA2F42925D21

→ **Hickel, Less Is More (2020) [any chapter or section]**
<https://blackbooksdotpub.wordpress.com/wp-content/uploads/2021/08/jason-hickel-less-is-more-random-house-2020.pdf>

→ **Selwyn, What might degrowth computing look like?**
https://csu-sjsu.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01CALS_SJO/1qa2v7t/cdi_unpaywall_primary_10_1080_17439884_2022_2159978

FIND

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SPARK

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FRICTION

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05

LOOK AT · ONE QUESTION

Damaged Earth Catalog

→ [Open the item](https://damaged.bleu255.com/) <https://damaged.bleu255.com/>

TAKE & SPECULATE

Move through the catalog until something stops you. Name the entry. Say what it is, and why that one.

Then take it somewhere in a speculative artwork path: describe what you would make that is inspired by this thing.

Write your answer here. This box keeps growing as you type.

THE ARTWORKS & VIDEO

Look and watch. Each of these sections contains one question, not six.

06

LOOK AT · ONE QUESTION

Solar Protocol

→ [Open the item](https://solarprotocol.net/) <https://solarprotocol.net/>

SPECULATE

This work lets an energy constraint decide what the viewer gets to see. Propose a speculative artwork of your own where a real, physical limit — sun, battery, weather, tide, bandwidth, a body — decides what the work does.

Describe it as though it already exists. Say what happens when the limit is generous, and what happens when it runs out.

Write your answer here. This box keeps growing as you type.

→ [Open the item](https://julianoliver.com/projects/harvest/) <https://julianoliver.com/projects/harvest/>

SPECULATE

Harvest turns a thing you might oppose into a funding mechanism for the opposite thing. Propose a speculative artwork built on the same concept: it runs on something you object to, and redirects what it produces.

Name the thing it runs on, what it produces, and where that output goes.

Write your answer here. This box keeps growing as you type.

→ [Open the item](https://100r.co/site/uxn.html) <https://100r.co/site/uxn.html>

SPECULATE

“We founded Hundred Rabbits so we could dedicate our time to the creation of small, playful, free, open-source software, while considering the impact of our works on the environment, and optimizing toward living more sustainably. We've adapted our software and projects around the limitations of our vessel instead of increasing its limits. We learned to appreciate these limits and think that they make our work better.

The benefits of many modern technologies today are illusory, and undermine people's self-sufficiency, freedom, and dignity. Ivan Illich proposed the concept of "convivial tools" that honor human agency and creativity. Convivial tools are not proprietary, in the style of many software today, but open-ended, flexible instruments that serve the needs and interests of ordinary individuals and communities.

We want our work to be an equal blend of aesthetics, playfulness, and practicality. We aim to keep our software small, portable and build from first principles to keep them participatory.”

Pick a tool that you rely on for making creative work and imagine you had to rebuild it under the conditions of the mission above. Describe the tool that you have created. What does the tool do? What does it look like? How does it work?

Write your answer here. This box keeps growing as you type.

→ [Boreal Dreams](https://www.jakobsteensen.com/boreal-dreams) <https://www.jakobsteensen.com/boreal-dreams>

SPECULATE

This work proposes possible futures impacted by climate change. Watch the video to get a good sense of the idea.

Propose a speculative artwork that moves through stages of a change in nature or the earth, rather than showing one fixed state.

Name the stages. Say what the viewer sees, hears or does at each. How does the piece work?

Write your answer here. This box keeps growing as you type.

Louis Henderson, *All That Is Solid* (2014)

→ [Video Data Bank](https://www.vdb.org/titles/all-solid) <https://www.vdb.org/titles/all-solid>

→ [Spectre Productions](https://www.spectre-productions.com/en/catalogue/all-that-is-solid) <https://www.spectre-productions.com/en/catalogue/all-that-is-solid>

REMAKE

“The video constructs a mise-en-abyme as critique in order to dispel the capitalist myth of the immateriality of new technology — thus revealing the mineral weight with which the Cloud is grounded to its earthly origins.”

“As technological progress pushes forward in the west, enormous piles of obsolete computers are thrown away and recycled. Pushed out of sight and sent to the coast of West Africa these computers are thrown into waste grounds such as Agbogbloshie in Accra, Ghana. On arrival the e-waste is recuperated by young men, who break and burn the plastic casings in order to extract the precious metals contained within.”

Think of a speculative artwork idea that would do the same thing: visualize the materiality of this computer waste and how it impacts people. What digital media would you use to make this artwork? What does it look like? How would it work?

Write your answer here. This box keeps growing as you type.

François Knoetze, *Core Dump* (2018–2019)

→ [Artist's page](https://francoisknoetze.com/core-dump-2018/) <https://francoisknoetze.com/core-dump-2018/>

→ [Recursive Colonialism](https://www.recursivecolonialism.com/opere/coredump/) <https://www.recursivecolonialism.com/opere/coredump/>

→ [Video](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4JqWoDBFNPQ) <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=4JqWoDBFNPQ>

SPECULATE

Knoetze builds bodies out of dead electronics and walks them through the cities where that waste travels. Propose a speculative artwork that gives a discarded technology a body, a voice, or a route.

What technologies are used, what do they become, where do they go, who encounters them?

Write your answer here. This box keeps growing as you type.

CONCLUSION

Three questions about the week as a whole. Answer them once everything above is done.

12

WRITE · 3 QUESTIONS

Overall thoughts on permacomputing & degrowth as a frame

OVERALL

Write around 5 sentences about your overall thoughts about how permacomputing and degrowth can help to frame discussions about digital media art and climate change, ecology, nature, and our planet. In what ways can it be a useful frame for digital media artists to make and discuss digital artwork?

Write your answer here. This box keeps growing as you type.

BEYOND

Which disciplines outside of art do the ideas in permacomputing or degrowth connect to? Pick one or two, from this list or from anywhere else:

architecture and urban planning · agriculture and food systems · engineering and energy · biology and ecology · computer science and machine learning · economics and labor · law and policy · public health · education · anthropology · geology and climate science · supply chains and logistics · disability studies · philosophy and religion

Then describe how or why the connection makes sense. Be specific: describe the idea from this week that connects to the discipline and describe how it relates.

Write your answer here. This box keeps growing as you type.

THREAD

Pick one of the disciplines that you listed above.

Come up with a question based on it, or follow a thread that you are interested in. Learn something in this other field.

For example, I learned from an article in my news feed that the color of the ocean is changing due to climate change.

<https://news.mit.edu/2023/study-oceans-color-changing-climate-change-0712> This sits in many disciplines, including biology. Once you learn something new in this new field, apply that to your speculative artwork idea from above. For my example, in mine, my scene will now have a greenish sea.

Describe here: the discipline, the thing you learned, and how it can be applied to your speculative artwork.

Write your answer here. This box keeps growing as you type.

SLIDE CREATION SECTION

One slide, built from what you wrote. Pull a line from any answer, add a drawing or photograph, and say what it is.

SLIDE TITLE

Name the idea in a few words.

THE LINE, AS IT WILL APPEAR

Paste a line from one of your answers above, then edit it freely.

WHAT IS IT? SAY IT WITH CONVICTION

What the image shows, and what it has to do with the line above.

YOUR DRAWING OR IMAGE

Paste your image into this box, or note here what you will place on the slide.

SLIDE CREATION

Now you will make your slides.

MAKE SLIDES

1. Use this template to create your slide or slides. [[https://docs.google.com/presentation/d/1v7aIEPHX8vyFP48sECYIA6muP6UqTYF3TyA_zfo4uh8/edit?usp=drive_link]]
2. Make a copy of the file before you start editing it.
3. Your presentation must be 1 minute or less.
4. You don't have to use my template; it is just a starting place if you need it.